

DON'T DIE RETIRED

Eat Strong

The four-week kitchen planner for people over 50

4-week planner · £12

dontdieretired.com

This planner is general information about food and cooking, not dietary or medical advice. If you have a diagnosed condition, take regular medication, or have kidney disease, check with your GP (family doctor) or a registered dietitian before changing what you eat.

Eat Strong

Four weeks to a kitchen that works for you after 50. Not a diet. Not a detox. A practical, unfussy way of shopping, cooking and eating that keeps your muscles, bones and energy on your side — and puts good food on the table without turning every evening into a project.

You are holding this because something has shifted. Perhaps you are cooking for fewer people than you used to. Perhaps your appetite is not what it was, or the same meals leave you flat by four o'clock. Perhaps you have simply noticed that the advice aimed at thirty-year-olds — more of this, less of that, count everything — has never quite fitted your life, and fits it less every year.

Eat Strong is built on one idea: **after 50, the job of food changes**. Earlier in life most of us ate to fuel a busy day and worried about eating too much. From here on, the bigger risk for many people is quietly eating too little of the things that hold the body together — protein, calcium, fibre, fluid — while the easy foods creep in. This planner is about getting those foundations right, in ways you will actually keep doing. There is no weighing, no counting, and no food you are forbidden.

How to use this planner

Read Parts 1 to 3 in one sitting (about 45 minutes).

Do the pantry checklist and print the shopping template before Week 1.

Then follow the four-week plan one week at a time. Each day has a single small task — a habit or a bit of cooking — not a menu to obey.

Dip into the recipe outlines in Part 5 whenever a task calls for one. They are outlines, not rules: swap, adjust, use what you have.

Part 1: What changes after 50

None of this is a decline to be fought. It is a set of ordinary changes that reward a slightly different approach to food. Knowing about them means you can work with them rather than being caught out.

Appetite gets quieter

Many people find that hunger becomes a less reliable prompt as the years go by. You can go longer without noticing you have not eaten, and a modest plate fills you sooner than it used to. On its own that is no problem. The catch is that when appetite is quiet, the meals that get skipped tend to be the ones that matter — the breakfast with some protein in it, the proper lunch — and the gap gets filled later with biscuits and toast. Eat Strong leans towards **smaller, more regular meals with something substantial in each**, rather than one big evening plate and not much else.

Muscle needs more encouragement

Muscle is built and maintained in response to two things: using it, and feeding it. From middle age onwards the body becomes a little less responsive to both, which is why a week in bed with flu costs an older person more strength than it costs a teenager, and why it takes longer to get back. The practical answer is well established: **regular protein through the day, and regular use of your muscles** — carrying shopping, climbing stairs, gardening, and ideally some deliberate strength work. This planner handles the food half. Our companion product, Strong at 60, handles the other.

Bones are quietly remodelling

Bone is living tissue that is constantly broken down and rebuilt. From mid-life the rebuilding side of that balance slows, especially for women after the menopause. Two things in the diet support the rebuilding side: calcium (the material) and vitamin D (which helps you absorb and use it). Both are easy to fall short on in the UK — the first because dairy intake often drops with age, the second because our winter sunlight is not strong enough to make it. Part 2 covers both plainly.

Thirst is a less trustworthy messenger

The British Dietetic Association puts it simply: as you get older, you might not recognise the feeling of thirst in the same way that you used to. That means waiting to feel thirsty is no longer a good plan. It also means the usual advice — check the colour of your urine — is less reliable in older adults, according to the same source. The fix is not complicated: **drink to a routine rather than to thirst**. A glass with each meal, a glass with any tablets, a cup mid-morning and mid-afternoon. Tea and coffee count.

The plain summary

Hunger and thirst become quieter signals — so eat and drink to a routine, not a feeling.

Muscle and bone still respond to food, but they need steadier supplies of protein, calcium and vitamin D than they used to.

Nothing here needs weighing or counting. It needs a few habits and a stocked cupboard.

Part 2: The building blocks

Six things to get roughly right. Each has a short 'why', a short 'how much' from a source we have actually read, and a handful of everyday ways to do it. You do not need to be perfect at any of them; you need to be reasonably consistent.

1. Protein, spread across the day

Protein is the raw material for muscle, and older bodies use it less efficiently than younger ones. The most-cited expert position on this, from the international PROT-AGE Study Group (published in 2013 and still the reference point), recommends that healthy older adults aim for **1.0 to 1.2 grams of protein per kilogram of body weight per day** — more than the standard adult figure — and that this is best taken as **25 to 30 grams of protein per meal** rather than one large helping at dinner. The European clinical nutrition society ESPEN gives the same 1.0 to 1.2 g/kg figure for healthy older people, according to a 2024 review by Groenendijk and colleagues. The US Administration for Community Living's protein tip sheet for older adults uses the same 25–30 grams per meal as a rule of thumb.

You do not need to calculate this. What it means in practice is simple: **put something protein-rich in every meal, including breakfast**, and do not save it all for the evening. Toast and jam for breakfast, soup for lunch, then a big roast at seven gives your muscles one usable delivery a day. Eggs or yoghurt at breakfast, beans or fish at lunch, and a normal dinner gives them three. The table below gives everyday protein foods with the standard adult portion sizes published by the British Dietetic Association, converted roughly into ounces. It is a guide to what 'a portion' looks like, not a target to hit at every meal.

- **Breakfast** is where most people fall short. Eggs, Greek-style yoghurt, porridge made with milk and a spoon of peanut butter, baked beans on toast, cottage cheese, kippers if you are that way inclined.
- **Lunch** is the second gap, especially if it has become 'a sandwich'. Add tinned fish, cheese, hummus, a hard-boiled egg, or leftover chicken. Soup gets a tin of beans or lentils stirred in.
- **Dinner** usually looks after itself. If anything, shift some of it earlier in the day.
- **Snacks** can do quiet work: a handful of nuts, a piece of cheese, a pot of yoghurt, a glass of milk.
- **Plant proteins are excellent** — beans, lentils, chickpeas, tofu, nuts, seeds — and cheaper. They tend to be less concentrated than meat, fish, eggs and dairy, so use generous portions and combine them: lentils with bread, beans with rice, hummus with a wholemeal pitta.

Food	One portion (BDA)	Roughly in ounces	Looks like
Cooked meat or poultry (beef, pork, lamb, mince, chicken, turkey)	90 g	About 3 oz	A deck of cards
Fish — white or oily (cod, plaice, salmon, mackerel, sardines)	140 g	About 5 oz	The palm of your hand
Eggs	120 g (two medium)	About 4 oz	Two eggs
Beans and pulses (baked beans, kidney beans, butter beans, lentils, chickpeas)	150 g	About 5 oz	Four tablespoons
Tofu, soya and meat alternatives	100 g	About 3½ oz	Four tablespoons
Nuts	30 g	About 1 oz	One handful
Cheese	30 g	About 1 oz	A small matchbox

Food	One portion (BDA)	Roughly in ounces	Looks like
Yoghurt	125–150 g	About 4–5 oz	One standard pot
Milk	200 ml	About 7 fl oz ($\frac{1}{2}$ pint)	One glass

If you have kidney disease

The PROT-AGE group is explicit that people with severe kidney disease who are not on dialysis are an exception and may need to limit protein. If you have any kidney condition, or you are not sure, talk to your GP or a registered dietitian before increasing protein. Everything else in this planner still applies.

2. The plate method

The UK's Eatwell Guide (published by the NHS) shows a balanced day as roughly a third fruit and vegetables, a third starchy foods — preferably wholegrain — and the rest split between protein foods and dairy or alternatives, with a little unsaturated oil and only occasional foods high in fat, salt and sugar. You do not need the chart on your fridge. You need a way of looking at a plate. It works in a café, at a buffet, at a friend's house and with a ready meal (add a bag of salad or a microwaved portion of frozen veg), and there is nothing to log. This is it:

1. **Half the plate: vegetables, salad or fruit.** Fresh, frozen or tinned all count. The Eatwell Guide asks for at least five 80 g portions of fruit and vegetables a day — an 80 g portion is about a clenched fist, or three heaped tablespoons.
2. **A quarter: something protein-rich.** Use the portion table above as a guide. Fish at least twice a week, one of them oily (salmon, sardines, mackerel) — the Eatwell Guide gives 2 x 140 g portions.
3. **A quarter: starchy food, wholegrain where you can.** Potatoes, wholemeal bread, brown rice, wholewheat pasta, oats. This is where most of your fibre lives.
4. **Add:** a glass of milk or a yoghurt somewhere in the day, and a little olive or rapeseed (canola) oil in the cooking.

3. Fibre

Fibre keeps your gut moving, feeds the bacteria that live there, helps you feel full and is associated with a long list of good outcomes. The British Dietetic Association says adults should aim for **around 30 grams a day**, and that the UK average is around 18 grams — so most of us have room to improve. The BDA gives two pieces of practical advice we would underline: **increase fibre gradually**, to avoid bloating and wind while your gut adjusts, and **drink plenty of fluid** alongside it, because fibre needs water to do its job. Fibre without fluid can make constipation worse, not better.

- Swap white bread, rice and pasta for wholemeal or wholegrain versions, one at a time.
- Keep the skins on potatoes, apples and pears.
- Beans and lentils are the easiest big fibre win: a tin into any soup, stew, chilli or salad.
- Porridge oats, shredded wheat or a bran-based cereal at breakfast, with fruit on top.
- A handful of nuts or seeds most days.
- Frozen vegetables in the freezer at all times — the BDA specifically suggests it, and so do we. They are as nutritious as fresh and never go off.

4. Calcium and vitamin D

Calcium is what bone is made of; vitamin D is what lets you absorb it. The BDA's calcium fact sheet gives the standard adult requirement as **700 mg a day**, and lists higher figures for some groups, including people on certain osteoporosis treatments — if that might be you, ask your GP or read the BDA sheet rather than guessing. The good news is that calcium is easy to reach with everyday food. According to the same sheet, a 200 ml glass of cow's milk, a 30 g piece of Cheddar and a 150 g pot of plain yoghurt each provide around 240 mg; 100 g of calcium-set tofu gives about 300 mg; half a tin of sardines with the bones about 240 mg; and 100 g of boiled kale about 150 mg. Fortified plant milks vary, so check the label for 'calcium'.

Vitamin D is different, because most of it comes from sunlight on skin rather than from food, and from October to early March the UK sun is not strong enough. The NHS advice is clear and it is the **one supplement this planner mentions**: everyone should consider taking a daily supplement containing **10 micrograms of vitamin D during the autumn and winter**, and people who are housebound, in a care home, who usually cover their skin outdoors or who have darker skin should consider taking it all year round. The NHS also says adults should not take more than 100 micrograms a day. Food sources are oily fish, red meat, egg yolks and fortified foods such as some spreads and breakfast cereals — but food alone is unlikely to be enough in a British winter. Readers in the sunnier parts of the US may be in a different position; the principle (sun in summer, think about it in winter) still holds.

- Milk on porridge and in tea and coffee adds up over a day.
- Tinned sardines or salmon with the bones, mashed on toast, is one of the cheapest calcium-rich lunches there is.
- Yoghurt as a pudding or a snack.
- Cheese grated over vegetables, soup or pasta.
- If you avoid dairy, choose calcium-fortified plant milks and yoghurts and calcium-set tofu.

About supplements, generally

The autumn-and-winter vitamin D supplement is the only one we mention, because the NHS recommends it for everyone. We are not going to suggest any others. If a shop, a website or a well-meaning friend recommends a pill for 'muscle', 'bones', 'energy' or 'ageing', the honest position is that a varied diet does the job for most people, and anything beyond that is a conversation for your GP or a registered dietitian — not a planner.

5. Hydration

The BDA's guidance for older adults is **at least 1,600 ml (about 3 pints) of fluid a day for women and at least 2,000 ml (about 3½ pints) for men**, more in hot weather. The NHS Eatwell Guide puts it as 6 to 8 cups or glasses a day. Crucially, **all fluids count** — the BDA lists water, tea, coffee, hot chocolate, milk, squash, fruit juice, fizzy drinks and weak alcoholic drinks up to 4% ABV — so nobody needs to force down water they do not enjoy. (Keep fruit juice and smoothies to a combined 150 ml a day, per the Eatwell Guide, because of the sugar.) The BDA notes that dehydration in older adults can show up as headaches, tiredness, confusion, poor concentration, constipation and urinary infections — none of which announce themselves as 'thirst'. In practice: a full glass with every meal and with any tablets (the BDA's own suggestion); a cup mid-morning and mid-afternoon; a jug or bottle where you sit, because if it is in front of you, you drink it; and a cup you find easy and pleasant to hold, which sounds trivial and is not. Soups, stews, porridge, yoghurt and juicy fruit all contribute.

6. Alcohol, within the guidelines

This is not a temperance planner. But alcohol does count for more as the body changes, and it is worth knowing where the lines are. In the UK, the Chief Medical Officers' guidance, as published by the NHS, is that men and women should not regularly drink **more than 14 units a week**, and that if you do drink that much you should **spread it over three or more days** and have several drink-free days. A unit is 10 ml of pure alcohol. The NHS gives these unit values for common drinks:

Drink	Units (NHS)
Single spirit measure (25 ml, 40% ABV)	1 unit
Small glass of wine (125 ml, 12% ABV)	1.5 units
Standard glass of wine (175 ml, 12% ABV)	2.1 units
Pint of lower-strength beer (3.6% ABV)	2 units
Pint of higher-strength beer or lager (5.2% ABV)	3 units

So 14 units is roughly six pints of ordinary-strength lager or six 175 ml glasses of wine across a week — comfortably a glass most evenings, not a bottle. In the US the picture has recently changed. The 2020–2025 Dietary Guidelines for Americans, as summarised by the CDC, advised two drinks or less in a day for men and one drink or less for women, where a standard US drink (12 oz of 5% beer, 5 oz of 12% wine, or 1.5 oz of 80-proof spirits) contains 14 grams of pure alcohol — a shade more than a UK unit and a half. The 2025–2030 edition, published in January 2026, dropped those numbers in favour of the plainer line 'consume less alcohol for better health', as AARP reported. Our suggestion for readers on either side of the Atlantic: keep to the UK limit, keep some days clear, and never let a drink stand in for a meal.

Part 3: Cooking for real life

Knowing what to eat is the easy part. The hard part is a Tuesday in February when you are tired, the fridge is bare and cooking for one feels pointless. This part is about the systems that make good food the path of least resistance.

Cooking for one or two

The single biggest change for many readers is the number of people at the table. Recipes are written for four, packaging is sized for families, and the temptation to 'just have toast' is strong when nobody else is eating. Three principles help.

- **Cook twice, eat four times.** Almost everything in Part 5 makes two generous portions or four modest ones. Eat one tonight, put one in the fridge for tomorrow's lunch, freeze the rest. Cooking for one becomes cooking for one *future* you as well.
- **Buy in the sizes you use.** Loose vegetables rather than bagged. Small tins. Individual fish fillets from the freezer. A pack of chicken thighs split and frozen on the day you buy it. Eggs, which keep for weeks.
- **Make the table a place.** Lay it, even for one. Sit down. Put the phone elsewhere. It is not indulgence; people who eat at a table tend to eat properly, and people who eat standing at the counter tend to eat crackers.

Batch cooking, the unheroic way

Batch cooking does not mean a Sunday lost to Tupperware. It means that whenever you cook something that freezes well, you make more of it than you need. Over a month the freezer fills itself. A workable routine:

1. **Pick two 'freezer bases' a week** — a soup, a stew, a chilli, a bolognese, a dal, a curry. Double the recipe. Cool, portion, label with the name and the date (you will not remember), freeze flat in bags or in old takeaway tubs.
2. **Cook a tray of something plain** alongside — roasted vegetables, baked chicken thighs, a pot of lentils or brown rice. These are not meals; they are the makings of three lunches.
3. **Keep a running freezer list** on the door. Cross things off as you use them. When the list gets short, that is your cue, not an empty freezer at 7 pm.
4. **Defrost in the fridge overnight** or use the microwave defrost setting; reheat until piping hot right through; do not refreeze something that has already been frozen and thawed.
5. **Use a slow cooker if you have one.** Everything in, low, out for the day, dinner and three freezer portions waiting when you get back.

Budget shopping — UK and US

Eating well for strength does not need to cost more; in many cases it costs less, because beans, eggs, oats, tinned fish and frozen vegetables are among the cheapest things in the shop. The BDA's 'Eat well, spend less' fact sheet makes several points worth adopting: plan your main meals and write a list; compare price per kilogram or per 100 g rather than trusting the offer sticker; try own-brand and value ranges, which the BDA says often taste just as good; check the top and bottom shelves, not just eye level; buy 'wonky' and loose produce; and use frozen and tinned, which the BDA notes keep their nutrients well. Reduced-to-clear shelves (UK) and manager's specials (US) are ideal for meat and fish you will freeze the same day; markets, world-food shops and discounters are often cheapest for pulses, spices, rice and vegetables; and the freezer is a bank, not a museum — things go in to be taken out.

Good-value protein	UK examples	US examples
Eggs	A dozen medium eggs, own-brand	A dozen large eggs, store brand
Tinned fish	Sardines, mackerel, pilchards, tuna — own-brand tins	Canned sardines, mackerel, salmon, tuna — store brand
Beans and pulses	Tins of chickpeas, kidney and butter beans; bags of red lentils; baked beans	Canned or dried black beans, pinto beans, chickpeas; bagged lentils
Dairy	Milk, natural yoghurt in large pots, cottage cheese, block Cheddar	Milk, plain yogurt in large tubs, cottage cheese, block cheese
Frozen	Chicken thighs, white fish fillets, mixed vegetables, peas, spinach	Chicken thighs, fish fillets, mixed vegetables, edamame
Store cupboard	Peanut butter, oats, tinned tomatoes, rice, pasta	Peanut butter, oats, canned tomatoes, rice, pasta

Eating out

- **The plate method travels.** Restaurants, pubs, cafés and other people's kitchens are part of a good life, and a planner that made you dread them would be a bad planner. Look for the protein, look for the vegetables, and let the rest follow.
- **Order protein first.** Grilled fish, roast chicken, steak, an omelette, a bean chilli. Then add vegetables or salad as a side if the plate is short of them.
- **Sharing plates and starters** are good friends to a smaller appetite. Two starters can make a better meal than one heavy main.
- **Breakfasts out** are an easy win: eggs any way, smoked salmon, beans on toast, porridge.
- **Ask for the box.** In the US it is routine; in the UK it is increasingly normal and nobody minds. Tomorrow's lunch is sorted.
- **Drink water alongside** whatever else you order, and count the wine in your week.
- **At a friend's house,** eat what you are given and enjoy it. One meal never made or broke anything.

The pantry checklist

A stocked cupboard, fridge and freezer mean that on the worst evening of the week there is still a decent meal twenty minutes away. Tick what you have; the rest is your first shopping list. You do not need all of it — but you do need most of the first column.

- ☐ Tinned tomatoes, tinned beans (three kinds), tinned chickpeas, red lentils
- ☐ Tinned sardines, mackerel, tuna or salmon
- ☐ Porridge oats; a wholegrain breakfast cereal
- ☐ Wholemeal bread (freeze half the loaf), wholewheat pasta, brown rice, couscous or bulgur
- ☐ Peanut butter; a bag of mixed nuts; a bag of seeds
- ☐ Olive oil or rapeseed (canola) oil; a vinegar; soy sauce
- ☐ Stock cubes or bouillon; dried herbs; a curry powder or paste; smoked paprika; chilli flakes; cumin; black pepper
- ☐ Onions, garlic, potatoes, carrots
- ☐ Eggs; milk; natural yoghurt; a block of hard cheese; butter or spread
- ☐ Frozen peas, frozen spinach, frozen mixed vegetables, frozen sweetcorn

- ☐ Frozen chicken thighs or portions; frozen white fish fillets; frozen salmon
- ☐ Frozen berries; frozen bread rolls
- ☐ Two or three of your own batch-cooked meals, labelled and dated
- ☐ Tinned or jarred: sweetcorn, olives, pesto, passata
- ☐ Lemons or lemon juice; fresh ginger (freezes well); fresh chillies (also freeze)
- ☐ Honey or marmalade; dark chocolate; tea and coffee you actually like

The weekly shopping template

Print this, or copy it into a notebook, and fill it in once a week before you shop. The first column is the plan; the others are the list. Doing it after breakfast on the same day each week turns it into a ten-minute habit.

Day	Main meal plan	Protein to buy	Veg / fruit to buy	Store cupboard / dairy / other
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				
Batch-cook this week				
Breakfast and lunch staples				

Part 4: The four-week plan

Each day has one small task. Some are habits, some are a bit of cooking, some are just noticing. None takes longer than an hour and most take ten minutes. Tick the box, and if you like, write a word about how it went. The weeks build: Week 1 sets up, Week 2 adds protein habits, Week 3 works on the kitchen systems, Week 4 makes it yours. If you miss a day, do the next one. Nothing here needs catching up.

Week 1 — Set up the kitchen

Day	Do this	Done / how did it feel?
Mon	Do the pantry checklist in Part 3. Make your first shopping list from the gaps. Put a jug or bottle of water where you usually sit.	☐
Tue	Shop from the list — after breakfast, not before. Buy one thing from the 'good-value protein' table you have not bought for a while.	☐
Wed	Protein breakfast day. Eggs, yoghurt, beans on toast, or porridge made with milk and a spoon of peanut butter. Notice how the morning goes.	☐
Thu	Cook one freezer base from Part 5 (the soup, the chilli or the dal). Eat one portion; freeze the rest, labelled and dated.	☐
Fri	Lay the table for your evening meal, even if it is only you. Sit, no screen. Add a glass of water.	☐
Sat	Fish day. Fresh, frozen or tinned — the sardines on toast or the salmon tray-bake are both in Part 5.	☐
Sun	Fill in the weekly shopping template for next week. Start the freezer list on the door. Look back at the week: which day felt best?	☐

Week 2 — Protein through the day

Day	Do this	Done / how did it feel?
Mon	Protein at breakfast, every day this week. Decide tonight what tomorrow's is, so there is no thinking at 7 am.	☐
Tue	Upgrade lunch: add tinned fish, cheese, an egg, hummus or leftover meat to whatever you would normally have.	☐
Wed	Try a plant-protein main — the dal, the bean chilli or the chickpea and spinach curry. Serve with bread or rice.	☐
Thu	Snack audit. Put a bowl of nuts, some cheese and a couple of yoghurts where the biscuits usually live. Move the biscuits, not bin them.	☐
Fri	Drink to a routine today: a glass with each meal, one with any tablets, a cup mid-morning and mid-afternoon. Tea counts.	☐
Sat	Cook the second freezer base of the week and double it. Two portions in the freezer minimum.	☐

Day	Do this	Done / how did it feel?
Sun	Weekly template again. This time, plan three protein breakfasts and two 'upgraded' lunches on it. Buy for them.	☐

Week 3 — Fibre, bones and the freezer

Day	Do this	Done / how did it feel?
Mon	One wholegrain swap: wholemeal bread, brown rice, wholewheat pasta or oats — pick one and keep it this week. Extra glass of water with it.	☐
Tue	Calcium check. Count today's milk, yoghurt, cheese, tinned fish with bones, tofu or fortified plant milk. If it was thin, add a yoghurt tonight.	☐
Wed	Freezer night. Eat something you batch-cooked in Week 1 or 2. Add a bag of frozen veg or a salad. Cross it off the door list.	☐
Thu	Tin-of-beans day: stir a tin into a soup, a stew, a salad or a pasta sauce. Note whether your gut is happy — go gradually if not.	☐
Fri	If it is autumn or winter where you are, buy a 10-microgram vitamin D supplement (NHS advice) and put it next to the kettle. In summer, put a note in the calendar for October.	☐
Sat	Eat out, or eat at someone's house, using the plate method. Protein first, vegetables second, water alongside. Enjoy it.	☐
Sun	Weekly template. Add a column of your own if you need one. Check the freezer list: aim to have four home-cooked portions in there by next Sunday.	☐

Week 4 — Make it yours

Day	Do this	Done / how did it feel?
Mon	Write down your three favourite meals from the last three weeks. These are your 'defaults' — the meals you make without thinking.	☐
Tue	Cook a new recipe outline from Part 5 that you have not tried yet. Change one thing about it to suit you.	☐
Wed	Count your drink-free days so far this week. If there are none, make tonight one.	☐
Thu	Cook for someone, or with someone. A neighbour, a friend, a grandchild, a partner. Double whatever it is and send a portion home with them.	☐
Fri	Kitchen tidy: throw out what has expired, refill the pantry gaps, re-date the freezer list. Ten minutes.	☐
Sat	A full plate-method day, breakfast to dinner, without looking anything up. Notice how automatic it has	☐

Day	Do this	Done / how did it feel?
	become.	
Sun	Final review, below. Fill in the weekly template one more time — then keep doing it every Sunday. That is the habit this planner was for.	☐

End-of-month review

Which of the six building blocks (protein, plate, fibre, calcium and vitamin D, hydration, alcohol) is now automatic?

Which one still needs a prompt? Put that prompt where you will see it.

How many home-cooked portions are in the freezer?

What are your three default meals?

What is the one thing you would tell a friend who was starting this?

Part 5: Recipe outlines

These are outlines, not recipes with grams and minutes to the second. Each makes two generous portions or four modest ones unless it says otherwise, follows the plate method without you having to think about it, and freezes where noted. Quantities are deliberately loose: 'a tin' is a standard 400 g (14 oz) tin; 'a handful' is your handful. Season to taste. Where a UK word differs from the US one, both are given.

Breakfasts

Porridge with a protein boost. Put a mug of porridge oats (rolled oats) in a pan with two mugs of milk and a pinch of salt, and cook gently, stirring, until thick — five minutes or so. Stir in a heaped spoon of peanut butter or a handful of chopped nuts, and top with a handful of frozen berries, which will thaw in the heat. A spoon of natural yoghurt on top adds more protein and calcium. Makes two; it also microwaves well the next day with a splash more milk.

Eggs with greens. Wilt a large handful of spinach (fresh or a block of frozen, squeezed dry) in a little oil in a small frying pan. Beat two eggs with salt, pepper and a spoon of grated cheese, pour over the greens and stir gently over a low heat until just set — softer than you think. Slide onto wholemeal toast. Serves one; takes seven minutes; swap the spinach for leftover roasted vegetables, a chopped tomato or a spoon of pesto whenever you like.

Lunches

Sardines on toast, properly. Toast two slices of wholemeal bread. Mash a tin of sardines (with the bones, for the calcium) with a squeeze of lemon, a spoon of natural yoghurt or mayonnaise, black pepper and, if you have them, a few chopped spring onions (scallions) or a spoon of capers. Pile onto the toast and grill for two minutes until it colours at the edges. Sliced tomato or a handful of rocket (arugula) alongside completes the plate. Serves one; takes eight minutes; swap in tinned mackerel or salmon.

Bean and tuna salad. Drain a tin of cannellini or mixed beans and a tin of tuna into a bowl. Add a chopped red onion or a few spring onions, a handful of cherry tomatoes halved, a chopped cucumber or pepper, and a big handful of any leaves. Dress with olive oil, lemon juice or vinegar, salt and pepper. Toss and eat with a wholemeal pitta or a slice of bread. Serves two; keeps a day in the fridge; the tuna can be replaced with a boiled egg, feta or leftover chicken.

Quick lentil and vegetable soup. Soften a chopped onion and two chopped carrots in oil in a large pan for five minutes. Add a mug of red lentils, a tin of chopped tomatoes, a teaspoon of cumin or curry powder, and a litre (about 4 cups) of stock. Simmer for twenty to twenty-five minutes until the lentils have collapsed, then blend if you like it smooth or leave it rustic. Salt, pepper, a squeeze of lemon. Makes four portions; freezes beautifully; a spoon of yoghurt on top adds protein.

Suppers

Salmon and vegetable tray-bake. Heat the oven to 200°C (400°F). Toss chopped potatoes, a sliced courgette (zucchini) and a sliced pepper with oil, salt and pepper on a large baking tray and roast for twenty minutes. Push them aside, lay two salmon fillets (fresh or frozen-and-thawed) on the tray, add a handful of cherry tomatoes and a squeeze of lemon, and return to the oven for twelve to fifteen minutes until the fish flakes. Serve with a spoon of yoghurt mixed with chopped herbs. Serves two; works with cod, chicken thighs or halloumi, and with any vegetables in the drawer.

Chicken thighs with beans and greens. Brown four skin-on chicken thighs in an ovenproof pan with a little oil, skin side down first, until golden — about eight minutes. Turn them, add a chopped onion, two crushed garlic cloves, a tin of butter beans with their liquid, a mug of stock and a sprig of thyme or rosemary. Transfer to a 190°C (375°F) oven for thirty-five minutes. Stir in a big handful of spinach or kale for the last five minutes. Serves two generously with crusty bread; freezes well without the greens.

Bean chilli, no meat required. Soften a chopped onion and a chopped pepper in oil for five minutes; add two crushed garlic cloves, a teaspoon each of cumin and smoked paprika and a pinch of chilli flakes, and stir for a minute. Add two tins of beans (kidney, black, pinto — any mix), a tin of chopped tomatoes and half a mug of stock. Simmer for twenty-five minutes, stirring now and then, until thick. Serve over brown rice or a baked potato with yoghurt or grated cheese and a handful of salad. Makes four portions; freezes for months; add minced (ground) beef or turkey at the start if you prefer.

Red lentil dal. Rinse a mug of red lentils. In a pan, soften a chopped onion in oil with a thumb of grated ginger and two crushed garlic cloves, then add a heaped teaspoon of curry powder or a spoon of curry paste and stir for a minute. Add the lentils, a tin of chopped tomatoes and three mugs of water, and simmer gently for twenty-five minutes, stirring occasionally, until soft and thick. Stir in a block of frozen spinach or a handful of fresh, and salt to taste. Serve with rice or warm wholemeal flatbreads and a spoon of yoghurt. Makes four; freezes perfectly; the dal is a foundation you can add roasted vegetables, a fried egg or leftover chicken to.

One-pan pasta with tuna, peas and lemon. Cook a generous two handfuls of wholewheat pasta in salted water; two minutes before it is done, throw in a large handful of frozen peas. Drain, keeping a splash of the water. Back in the pan, stir in a drained tin of tuna, a spoon of olive oil, the zest and juice of half a lemon, a handful of grated Parmesan or Cheddar, black pepper and the reserved water to loosen. A spoon of crème fraîche or yoghurt makes it creamier. Serves two; ten minutes; tinned salmon, a boiled egg or a handful of prawns (shrimp) all work instead.

Chickpea and spinach curry. Soften a chopped onion in oil, add two crushed garlic cloves, a thumb of grated ginger and two spoons of curry paste, and fry for a minute until fragrant. Add a tin of chickpeas (drained), a tin of chopped tomatoes and half a tin of coconut milk or a mug of stock. Simmer for fifteen minutes, then stir in a large handful of spinach until wilted. Season and finish with lemon. Serve with rice or a flatbread and yoghurt on the side. Makes two to three; freezes well; a couple of chicken thighs, chopped, can go in with the onion for a non-vegetarian version.

Baked potato with a proper filling. Scrub a large baking potato, prick it, and bake at 200°C (400°F) for an hour or so until the skin is crisp and the inside gives — or microwave for eight minutes and then crisp in the oven for fifteen. Split it and fill with something protein-rich: baked beans with grated cheese, tuna mixed with sweetcorn and yoghurt, cottage cheese with chives, leftover chilli or dal. Add a side of salad or coleslaw. Serves one; bake two potatoes at once and the second one reheats for tomorrow.

Batch bases and puddings

Slow-cooker beef or bean stew. Brown chunks of stewing beef in a hot pan (or skip this and use two tins of beans for a vegetarian version). Put into a slow cooker with a chopped onion, three chopped carrots, two chopped sticks of celery, a tin of chopped tomatoes, a mug of stock, a spoon of tomato purée (tomato paste) and a bay leaf. Cook on low for seven to eight hours, or in a low oven (160°C / 325°F) in a lidded pot for three hours. Add a tin of beans for the last half hour to stretch it. Makes six portions; freezes for months; serve with mashed potato, bread or brown rice and a green vegetable.

Roasted vegetable tray for the week. Heat the oven to 200°C (400°F). Chop whatever vegetables you have — peppers, courgettes (zucchini), red onions, carrots, squash, broccoli — into similar-sized pieces,

toss with oil, salt, pepper and a teaspoon of smoked paprika or dried herbs, and spread over two trays. Roast for thirty to forty minutes, turning once, until edges are caramelised. Cool and refrigerate in a tub. Through the week they go into omelettes, on toast with hummus, into pasta, alongside fish, or blended into the lentil soup. Keeps four days.

Fruit and yoghurt crumble pots. Warm a couple of handfuls of frozen berries or chopped apple with a spoon of water in a small pan until soft and jammy, about five minutes. Spoon into two glasses or bowls. Top each with a generous spoon of Greek-style yoghurt. For the crumble, toast a handful of oats and a handful of chopped nuts in a dry frying pan with a teaspoon of butter and a little honey or sugar for three or four minutes until golden, then scatter over. Serves two; a pudding with protein and calcium in it, which is more than most puddings can say.

Troubleshooting

"I'm just not hungry"

This is the commonest thing readers over 50 tell us about food, and the plan is built around it. Three things help. First, **eat to the clock, not to hunger**: breakfast, lunch and dinner at roughly the same times, with a small something mid-morning and mid-afternoon, and let appetite catch up. Second, **make the small meals count**: if you can only manage a little, make it yoghurt and nuts rather than a plain biscuit. Third, **drink after meals rather than before**, so fluid does not fill you up first. If your appetite has dropped suddenly, or you are losing weight without trying, that is a reason to see your GP, not a reason to try harder with a planner.

"My teeth, hands or grip make cooking hard"

Adjust the food and the tools, not the ambition. Softer proteins — eggs, fish, yoghurt, cottage cheese, lentils, beans, slow-cooked meat that falls apart — carry the plan just as well as a steak. Frozen pre-chopped onions, garlic and vegetables, tinned pulses, a small food processor, a good pair of kitchen scissors, a jar opener and a lightweight non-stick pan remove most of the hard work. A slow cooker asks nothing of your hands after the first ten minutes. If chewing or swallowing has become genuinely difficult, that is a GP or dentist conversation, and a registered dietitian can help with textures.

"I've been told to watch my salt, sugar, fat or blood sugar"

Then your GP, practice nurse, diabetes team or dietitian is the authority, and they win any argument with this planner. Nothing here should contradict them: the building blocks are mainstream and the recipes are ordinary food. But if you have a diagnosed condition — heart disease, diabetes, kidney disease, high blood pressure, or anything for which you take regular medication — show them the plan and ask what to adjust. It will usually be a matter of seasoning, portion, or which recipes to lean on. If they say something different from us, do what they say.

"The food is fine but the habits keep slipping"

Then it is a systems problem, not a willpower problem. Go back to the three systems in Part 3: the pantry (is it stocked?), the freezer list (is it on the door?), and the Sunday template (are you filling it in?). Nine times out of ten, one of them has lapsed. Restore it. And remember the rule from the four-week plan: **if you miss a day, do the next one**. There is no catching up, and no failing — only the next meal.

Finishing, and what next

If you have reached this page after four weeks, look at what has changed. There is food in the freezer that you made. Breakfast has something in it. You drink without being reminded. You can look at any plate, anywhere, and see what it needs. You have a piece of paper you fill in on a Sunday. None of that is dramatic, and all of it is the difference between a kitchen that supports you for the next thirty years and one that does not.

- **Keep the Sunday template.** Ten minutes a week is the whole system. Everything else follows from it.
- **Rotate the defaults.** Every couple of months, add one new recipe to your three defaults and let one rest. The list stays short; the food stays interesting.
- **Re-run Week 3 in October.** Fibre, calcium and the vitamin D supplement are the things that slide over summer. The week is a good annual reset.
- **Pair it with strength.** Food builds muscle only when muscle is used. If you have not started some deliberate strength work, our Strong at 60 plan is the natural companion.
- **Cook for someone monthly.** It keeps you cooking properly, and it is good for both of you.
- **Stay in touch.** Our weekly newsletter has one idea, one thing to try and one piece of honest evidence — no hype, no supplements (dontdieretired.com/newsletter) — and the members' circle is a small, friendly group of readers who swap recipes and freezer tricks (dontdieretired.com/circle).

One last thing

You already knew how to eat. What changed was what your body needs from food, and nobody told you.

Now you know. A stocked cupboard, a protein breakfast, a glass by your chair, and a list on a Sunday. Keep going.

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Every figure in this planner comes from one of the pages above, which we read before writing; where a number could not be verified, we described the idea in words instead. **Eat Strong** is a publication of dontdieretired.com. It offers general information about food and cooking and is not dietary or medical advice. If you have a diagnosed condition, take regular medication, or have kidney disease, check with your GP or a registered dietitian before changing what you eat.